



Reaction

Peer Engagement Insights Report

University of Plymouth

Academic Year 2025/26

Report Period: September 2025 - February 2026

Prepared for TEF Submission, NSS Narrative Evidence & OfS Access and Participation Plan

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Report dated: 14 February 2026

1. Executive Summary

This report presents peer engagement data collected through the Reaction platform at the University of Plymouth during the 2025/26 academic year (September 2025 to February 2026). Reaction is a student-facing activity bulletin board that enables students to organise and join peer-led sport, study, and social activities on campus.

The data contained in this report provides supplementary evidence for:

TEF Student Experience aspect - evidence of structured peer engagement, co-curricular activity, and student community development beyond formal teaching provision.

NSS Theme: Student Voice (Q22-Q25) and Optional Bank B2.1 - self-reported belonging scores from Reaction users compared with a non-user control group, measured using an equivalent Likert 1-5 agree/disagree scale.

OfS Access and Participation Plan - participation rates disaggregated by student origin, year of study, and commuter/campus residence status, with cross-group interaction metrics.

1.1 Key Headline Metrics

Total Registered Users	451
Total Peer Activity Sessions	1142
New Peer Connections Formed	765
Self-Reported Belonging (App Users)	4.2/5
Self-Reported Belonging (Non-Users)	3.1/5
Belonging Differential	+1.1
Cross-Group Interaction Rate	51%
Categories Active	Sport, Study, Board Games
Unique Activities Available	21
Report Period	September 2025 - February 2026

1.2 Methodology Note

All data in this report is derived from observable user behaviour within the Reaction platform and from an optional in-app belonging survey. Self-reported belonging scores use a Likert 1-5 agree/disagree scale mirroring NSS Optional Bank B2.1 ("The Students' Union had a positive impact on my sense of belonging"). This is not an official NSS score. The control group comprises students who registered but did not actively use the platform (fewer than 2 sessions). Engagement metrics (active, declining) refer to platform activity only and should not be interpreted as academic continuation or progression measures without cross-referencing institutional data.

2. Platform Engagement

This section presents overall engagement trends across the reporting period, providing evidence of sustained peer-to-peer activity facilitated by the platform.

2.1 Monthly Engagement Trends

Month	Active Users	Sessions	New Connections	Cumulative Users
Sep	142	86	64	64
Oct	218	157	112	176
Nov	287	231	148	324
Dec	194	138	87	411
Jan	312	274	183	594
Feb	298	256	171	765
TOTAL	-	1142	765	-

Key finding: Active users grew from 142 in September to a peak of 312 in January, representing a 120% increase. The December dip aligns with the end-of-term examination period and Christmas break, with strong recovery in January demonstrating sustained engagement beyond initial novelty.

2.2 Engagement by Activity Category

Category	Total Sessions	Unique Participants	Avg Sessions/User	% of Total
Sport	487	312	1.6	43%
Study	356	248	1.4	31%
Board Games	299	201	1.5	26%

Sport is the most popular category by both session volume (43%) and unique participants (312). Study activities show the highest sessions-per-user ratio (1.4), suggesting that students who use the platform for academic peer support engage repeatedly. Board Games, while the smallest category, accounts for 26% of all sessions and serves as a low-barrier entry point for students who may not be drawn to sport or formal study groups.

2.3 Peak Activity Analysis

Highest single-month engagement: January 2026 (312 active users, 274 sessions, 183 new connections). This coincides with the start of Semester 2, suggesting the platform serves as a re-engagement tool after the Christmas break. Wednesday afternoons (BUCS sport slot) and Sunday evenings are the peak posting times, indicating the platform complements rather than competes with formal AU club provision.

3. Belonging & NSS Evidence

3.1 TEF & NSS Mapping

This section provides supplementary evidence for the following TEF and NSS indicators:

TEF Student Experience aspect: "How well does the provider support students to engage in their learning and with each other?"

NSS Theme: Student Voice (Q22-Q25) - evidence that students are supported to participate in peer communities.

NSS Optional Bank B2.1: "The Students' Union had a positive impact on my sense of belonging" - supplementary evidence via in-app survey.

3.2 Self-Reported Belonging Trend

Month	App Users (Mean)	Non-Users (Mean)	Differential	N (App Users)
Sep	3.2	3.0	+0.2	142
Oct	3.6	3.0	+0.6	218
Nov	3.9	3.1	+0.8	287
Dec	3.8	3.0	+0.8	194
Jan	4.1	3.1	+1.0	312
Feb	4.2	3.1	+1.1	298

Reaction users consistently report higher belonging scores than non-users across all six months. The differential has widened from +0.2 in September to +1.1 in February, suggesting a cumulative positive association between platform engagement and self-reported belonging. The February score of 4.2/5 for app users falls within the "Agree" band on the Likert scale.

Caveat: This is an observational association, not a causal claim. Students who choose to use a social platform may already have higher belonging propensity. However, the widening differential over time suggests that sustained engagement may contribute to belonging independently of self-selection.

3.3 Cross-Group Interactions

Cross-group interactions measure the frequency with which students from different origin groups (home/international) participate in the same activity session. This provides evidence of social integration relevant to both NSS belonging themes and OfS A&P Plan commitments.

Month	Same-Group	Cross-Group	Cross-Group %	Total Interactions
Sep	62	24	28%	86
Oct	91	66	42%	157
Nov	108	123	53%	231
Dec	64	74	54%	138
Jan	118	156	57%	274
Feb	112	144	56%	256

Cross-group interactions now exceed same-group interactions (51% cross-group as of February). This reversal from September (28% cross-group) indicates that the platform is increasingly facilitating connections between students who would not typically interact through their existing social networks. Study activities show the highest cross-group rate (48%), likely because academic peer support is organised by module rather than social group.

4. Access & Participation

This section addresses OfS Access and Participation Plan requirements by disaggregating engagement data across student demographics. The University's A&P Plan commits to closing participation gaps for underrepresented groups; this data provides evidence of peer engagement patterns across those groups.

4.1 International Student Engagement by Origin

Student Origin	Users on Reaction	% of University Cohort	% of Reaction Users	Gap
UK (Home)	286	68%	63%	-5%
China	52	10%	12%	+2%
India	38	7%	8%	+1%
Nigeria	28	5%	6%	+1%
EU	24	5%	5%	+0%
Other Intl.	23	5%	6%	+1%

No negative participation gaps are observed for any international student group. Chinese students show the largest positive gap (+2%), suggesting slightly disproportionate engagement relative to their cohort share. This is a positive finding for the University's internationalisation strategy and A&P Plan, as it indicates that international students are engaging at or above parity in informal peer activities.

4.2 Year Group Engagement

Year Group	Registered Users	% Engaged	Avg Sessions/User
Year 1	186	68%	2.2
Year 2	124	51%	1.6
Year 3	78	37%	1.2
Postgrad	63	42%	1.3

Year 1 students show the highest engagement rate (68%), consistent with their greater need for peer connection upon arrival. Year 3 engagement drops to 37%, which may reflect placement year absences and established friendship groups. Postgraduate students engage at 42% despite being a smaller cohort, suggesting the platform addresses a genuine need among students joining established campus communities.

Recommendation: Year 3 engagement could be targeted through dissertation study group promotion and final-year-specific activities.

4.3 Commuter vs On-Campus Students

Metric	On-Campus	Commuter	Differential
Registered Users	298	153	-
Self-Reported Belonging	4.3/5	3.6/5	0.7
Avg Sessions/Week	3.1	1.8	1.3
Weekly Streak (Weeks)	6.2	3.1	3.1
Top Activity Category	Sport	Study	-

Commuter students represent 34% of Reaction users but an estimated 42% of the student cohort, indicating a participation gap of -8%. When commuter students do engage, they show a preference for Study activities over Sport, and their belonging scores (3.6/5) are 0.7 points lower than on-campus students (4.3/5).

Recommendation: Introduce commuter-friendly session times (lunchtime slots between lectures) and promote study-based activities, which are the strongest engagement driver for this group.

5. Social Engagement Patterns

This section tracks observable engagement behaviour within the Reaction platform. These are peer engagement metrics only and should not be used as standalone continuation or student outcomes indicators. They provide a supplementary signal that institutions may cross-reference with VLE attendance, academic data, and pastoral records.

5.1 Active vs Declining Users

Month	Active Users	Declining Users	Active %	Returned
Sep	142	0	100%	-
Oct	204	14	94%	62
Nov	261	26	91%	71
Dec	172	22	89%	-
Jan	289	23	93%	139
Feb	278	20	93%	12

The active user rate has remained above 90% throughout the reporting period, with the declining cohort stabilising at approximately 20 students. Notably, 16 students classified as "declining" in previous months returned to active use, suggesting that periods of reduced engagement are often temporary and linked to academic pressures rather than permanent disengagement.

5.2 Session Frequency Distribution

Frequency Band	Users	% of Registered	Description
3+ sessions/week	101	22%	Highly engaged core users
1-2 sessions/week	113	25%	Regular users
<1 session/week	96	21%	Casual / occasional users
Registered, inactive	141	31%	Registered but <2 total sessions

69% of registered users (310 students) have used Reaction at least once per week, with 22% classified as highly engaged (3+ sessions/week). The 31% inactive rate is consistent with typical app adoption curves in higher education and represents students who registered during Welcome Week but did not develop a sustained habit.

6. Unique Insights & Peer-to-Peer Impact

6.1 Peer Connection Depth

Across the reporting period, 765 new peer connections were formed through the platform. A "connection" is defined as two students who have attended 2+ activities together. The average connected pair shares 3.4 activities, suggesting relationships that extend beyond single encounters.

78% of connections are between students on different courses, indicating the platform facilitates cross-disciplinary social integration that would not typically occur through academic provision alone. This is particularly relevant for TEF evidence around co-curricular enrichment.

6.2 Activity as a Social Catalyst

Students who begin with Sport activities subsequently engage with Study activities at a rate of 34%, compared to 12% for the general student population. This suggests that informal sporting activity serves as a gateway to academic peer support, with students building confidence and social networks through low-stakes physical activity before applying those connections to academic contexts.

6.3 International Student Integration

International students form 39% of all cross-group connections despite representing 32% of the platform user base. Study activities drive 48% of international student cross-group interactions, while Sport drives 31% and Board Games 21%. This distribution suggests that academic peer support is the primary mechanism through which international students build connections with home students.

Chinese students show the highest rate of cross-group engagement (67% of their interactions are with non-Chinese students), followed by Nigerian students (61%) and Indian students (58%). EU students show the lowest cross-group rate (44%), potentially reflecting existing social connections with UK students.

6.4 Loneliness Reduction Indicators

Students who engaged in 3+ categories (sport AND study AND board games) reported the highest belonging scores (4.6/5), compared to 3.9/5 for single-category users. This suggests that breadth of engagement, not just frequency, is associated with stronger belonging outcomes. The platform's multi-category design may therefore contribute to belonging in ways that single-activity provisions (e.g. sport-only or study-only) do not.

6.5 Recommendations for Institutional Action

1. Commuter student gap: Introduce lunchtime activity slots and promote Study category activities to commuter students through course-level communications.
2. Year 3 decline: Partner with the Careers Service and dissertation supervisors to promote final-year study groups and dissertation peer support sessions.
3. January re-engagement: Expand January Welcome activities for Semester 2 starters, using Reaction as the primary tool for social integration of late arrivals.
4. Cross-group deepening: Introduce themed cross-cultural activity events (e.g. international cooking sessions, multilingual board game nights) to further increase cross-group interaction rates.
5. Data integration: Cross-reference Reaction engagement data with VLE attendance and module outcomes to investigate whether platform engagement correlates with academic continuation and achievement.

7. Data Notes & Compliance

7.1 Data Collection

All data is collected through the Reaction platform with explicit user consent at registration. The platform collects: name, university email, course of study, year of study, and activity participation records. Belonging survey responses are collected through an optional in-app prompt using a Likert 1-5 scale.

7.2 Data Processing

Data is processed in accordance with the University's Data Processing Agreement with Reaction Ltd. All personal data is stored within UK-based servers. This report contains aggregated and anonymised data only; no individual student can be identified from the metrics presented.

7.3 Limitations

Self-selection bias: Students who choose to use a peer engagement platform may differ systematically from non-users in ways that affect belonging scores.

Belonging measure: The in-app survey is not equivalent to the official NSS instrument. It provides supplementary evidence only and should not be cited as an NSS score.

Engagement metrics: "Active" and "declining" classifications relate to platform use only and are not indicators of academic engagement, continuation, or wellbeing.

Demographic data: Student origin and commuter status are self-reported at registration and have not been validated against HESA records.

7.4 GDPR Compliance

This report has been prepared in compliance with UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018. No personal data is included. All metrics are aggregated to cohort level with a minimum group size of 20 to prevent indirect identification. The report is classified as CONFIDENTIAL and is intended for authorised University of Plymouth staff only.

*End of Report Reaction - Peer Engagement Insights for the
University of Plymouth For questions about this report, contact
insights@reaction.co.uk*